Rise of Form: Sources for the Positive Turn

Sources note v0.2, Project secret3, Row B, August 11, 2026

Purpose: chapter two currently ends at the border of form. The author wants a positive ending: a level of existence that is not form, introduced through the most familiar door, our inner life, which we feel as rich and cannot give form. This note surveys the philosophy and psychology available to introduce that idea in Part One's register, mainstream, honest, no spiritual vocabulary, and recommends a spine.

1. Psychology first: the inner life that outruns form, measured

William James, The Principles of Psychology (1890), the Stream of Thought chapter. The founder of American psychology, describing consciousness as a stream, and insisting that its most living parts are the transitions, which vocabulary cannot hold: we ought to be able to speak of a feeling of and, a feeling of if, a feeling of but, as readily as a feeling of blue or cold. His point is exactly ours: introspection finds far more in a second of inner life than language has forms for, and the naming misrepresents the flow. Gives the section its psychological pedigree and its warmest sentence. Risk: none; universally respected. Fit: excellent as the opening authority.

Diana Raffman, Language, Music, and Mind (1993), nuance ineffability, with the standard psychophysics. Humans reliably discriminate on the order of millions of color shades and hold only a few dozen color words; between two adjacent paint chips you can see a difference you demonstrably cannot say. This is ineffability as a laboratory fact, not a mood: perception outruns categorization, in everyone, measurably. Gives the section a concrete scene, the paint chips, and an empirical floor. Risk: a deflationist can say the difference is still form, just unnamed form; the section should use this as the gentle first step, not the whole argument. Fit: excellent scene material.

Russell Hurlburt, Descriptive Experience Sampling, and unsymbolized thinking (with Akter, 2008). Decades of beeper studies: subjects carry a random beeper and report the last moment of inner life before the beep. A robust finding: a substantial share of sampled moments contain unsymbolized thinking, explicit thought that is present, definite, and in no words, no images, no symbols at all. Modern experimental psychology documenting inner events without form. Gives the section its contemporary empirical anchor and a good scene, the beeper. Risk: introspective methods are debated; report the finding with its method visible. Fit: strong.

Alexithymia (term coined by Sifneos, 1973). People who cannot name or describe their feelings still measurably have them; the physiology is rich where the vocabulary is empty. One supporting line: having is not naming. Fit: one sentence, no more.

2. The philosophical sharpeners

Thomas Nagel, What Is It Like to Be a Bat? (1974). The canonical modern statement: an organism is conscious when there is something it is like to be it, and this subjective character is precisely what objective, structural description leaves out, in principle, not by current ignorance. Gives the section its central phrase, something it is like, and its cleanest statement of the limit. Risk: none serious; it is the field's shared reference point. Fit: essential.

Frank Jackson, the knowledge argument, Mary (1982, 1986). Mary, the color scientist, knows every physical and structural fact about color, having lived in a black-and-white room; released, she sees red, and learns something. All the form, and still something new. This is our chapter's argument as a one-scene story. Honesty required, and it strengthens the section: the ability-hypothesis reply (she

gains a skill, not a fact) must be stated, and Jackson himself later abandoned the argument's anti-materialist conclusion. The datum, that the seeing was not in the knowing, is what survives every reply, and even the repliers keep it. Fit: the strongest single scene; use with both honesty beats.

Ned Block, phenomenal versus access consciousness (1995). The clean technical distinction the section can borrow in one sentence: access consciousness is information available for report and use, which is form-traffic and fully at home on the mountain; phenomenal consciousness is the experience itself. The distinction lets the section say precisely which half science's inventory captures. Fit: one paragraph of vocabulary.

Joseph Levine, the explanatory gap (1983). The moderate voice: even if materialism were true, the explanation of experience by structure would still leave a gap. Useful because it shows the point does not require any metaphysical commitment. Fit: one sentence, the modest version of the claim.

David Chalmers, the hard problem, and the structure-and-dynamics argument (1995, 2002). Physical explanation delivers structure and dynamics; from structure and dynamics only more structure and dynamics follow; experience is therefore not entailed. This is the chapter's own closure argument, stated in the profession's terms. Fit: cite as the formal twin of our substSteps intuition; the full treatment belongs to a later part.

3. The frame that makes the positive claim mainstream

Galileo's exclusion (Il Saggiatore, 1623), told through Philip Goff, Galileo's Error (2019). The historical key the section already half-uses: Galileo founded physics by deliberately setting the qualities, color as seen, sound as heard, outside its domain, keeping only the mathematizable, the form. Science's silence about experience is not a finding; it is the founding subtraction. Goff's popular book makes exactly this case at exactly our register. Fit: turns the fence paragraph into a doorway paragraph.

Russell (The Analysis of Matter, 1927) and Eddington (The Nature of the Physical World, 1928), completed. The chapter already cites their negative half: physics delivers structure and is silent on what bears it. Both men then took the positive step. Eddington's version, hedged as his: there is exactly one point in the universe where we know the inner nature of things and not merely their structure, and that point is our own consciousness, known by direct acquaintance, from inside. The same Eddington who built our fence opens the gate, which gives the section a structural rhyme the book could not have designed better. Fit: the recommended pivot; report as their position, held then and defended now.

Contemporary Russellian monism (Strawson 2006; Goff 2019; Chalmers's sympathetic treatments). The live, respectable descendant: form needs a bearer; the one bearer anyone is acquainted with is experience; so the level of existence that is not form is not exotic, it is the most familiar thing there is, and the only thing we know otherwise than through form. Risk, to be handled openly: pressed hard, this family of views runs toward panpsychism, a label the section should neither hide nor adopt; Part One needs only the modest claim, that at least one non-form level exists and each of us is standing in it. Fit: the positive proposal, correctly attributed, honestly scoped.

4. Voices to hold for later parts

Michel Henry's material phenomenology, life as invisible self-affection without form or world, is the deepest philosophical match to the book's theme and is explicitly religious in its late form; it belongs to The Reading, not to Part One. Zahavi's pre-reflective self-awareness, the mineness of experience prior to any content, is a bridge worth keeping for Part Two or later. Wittgenstein must be handled with care in this section: the Tractatus's closing, that what cannot be said shows itself,

points our way, but the private language argument of the Investigations is the standard weapon against ineffable inner reference, and since the chapter already quotes the Investigations for the deflationary side, the section should not lean on Wittgenstein at all.

5. Recommended spine for the section

Five beats, in order. One: the paint chips, and James, inner life outruns naming, psychology has said so since its founding (Raffman, James). Two: the beeper, thought with no form at all, measured (Hurlburt). Three: Mary, all the form and still something new, with both honesty beats attached (Jackson, Nagel's phrase, Block's distinction in one sentence). Four: the pivot, Galileo's founding subtraction, and Eddington completing his own fence: one place where the world is known from inside (Goff, Russell, Eddington). Five: the modest positive close, one level of existence that is not form, occupied by every reader at this moment, claimed at the strength Levine allows and no more, with the deflationist given one final honest nod and the larger question deferred, by name, to the later parts. What the section must not do: adopt panpsychism, use any spiritual vocabulary, or claim the argument settled. Scene candidates, in preference order: the paint chips opening into James; the beeper; Mary as the third movement rather than the opener, since the section before it already argued and this section should begin by showing.

6. Sources for the triad chapter (added at v0.2)

Thought is not language, the science layer. Hadamard, The Psychology of Invention in the Mathematical Field (1945): a survey of working mathematicians on how they think; the famous testimony is Einstein's letter, reproduced there, that words and language play no role in his mechanism of thought, whose elements are signs and images that come before any wording. Hurlburt's unsymbolized thinking (section 1 above) is the same fact from experimental sampling. Fedorenko and colleagues, in a line of work culminating in recent reviews: the brain's language network is dissociable from reasoning, patients with global aphasia who cannot process sentences still do arithmetic, logic, and theory of mind; the mainstream statement is that language and thought are not the same thing. Together: thought outruns language empirically, in testimony, in sampling, and in lesion neuroscience. Risk: none of this shows thought outruns the brain; the chapter must not claim it does at this layer.

Thought is not computation, the book's own layer. Chapter two's closure result with its compiled emblems, substSteps and the understanding-free checker; Searle and Harnad as the philosophical seconds. The exact claim available: whatever a machine does as computation is form-traffic, and meaning-carrying activeness is not in the closure; nothing about future machine performance follows, and the chapter says so.

The triad itself, the lineage layer. Plotinus, Enneads: the descent Nous, Psyche, Hyle, intellect active, soul mediating and receiving, matter as the outermost expression; the cleanest classical statement of the architecture. Aristotle, De Anima III.5: the active intellect against the receptive intellect, the active-receiving distinction drawn inside thought itself, disputed for two millennia and never dismissed. Paul, 1 Thessalonians 5:23: spirit, soul, and body in a single verse, the Christian anthropology's three levels. The Vedantic witness, sakshi, as the pure receiver to which experience is given, the strongest articulation of consciousness as receptive rather than active. And the teaching this book keeps company with, which is unusually exact here: spirit as active thought, the causal level, and consciousness named the level of perception, receptive, which is the position this book's triad takes and which separates it from consciousness-first framings. Steiner's threefold spirit, soul, and body may be cited as the modern German articulation of the same architecture, hedged as his. Risks: the word trinity invites theological confusion with the divine Trinity and

should be avoided in the chapter title; the triad is anthropology and ontology, not Trinitarian doctrine, and the notes should say so in one sentence.